

Excode (excode.in) — SEO, Analytics & Search Ranking Setup Plan

Post-AWS-deployment checklist to get Excode fully indexed, tracked, and optimized.

Phase 0: Pre-flight checks (before touching any tool)

- ☐ Confirm `excode.in` resolves correctly to the AWS deployment (check DNS A/CNAME records via Route 53 or your registrar)
 - ☐ Confirm SSL/HTTPS is live and forced (no mixed content, HTTP redirects to HTTPS) — use an Nginx/ALB redirect rule if not already set
 - ☐ Confirm `www.excode.in` and `excode.in` don't both serve duplicate content — pick one canonical version and 301-redirect the other
 - ☐ Confirm the site returns proper HTTP status codes (200 for real pages, 404 for missing ones, not soft-404s that return 200)
 - ☐ Make sure the site isn't accidentally blocking crawlers (check for `noindex` meta tags left over from staging)
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Phase 1: Search Engine Indexing

Google Search Console

1. Go to search.google.com/search-console
2. Add property → use **Domain property** (covers all subdomains/protocols) via DNS TXT record verification through Route 53 — more robust than the URL-prefix method
3. Submit sitemap: `https://excode.in/sitemap.xml`
 - If you don't have one yet, generate it dynamically (Next.js: `next-sitemap` package; Express: write a route that returns XML)
4. Use **URL Inspection tool** → manually request indexing for your key pages (home, pricing, key feature/landing pages)
5. Check **Coverage report** after a few days for crawl errors
6. Set up **Core Web Vitals report** monitoring (Phase 4 below)

Bing Webmaster Tools

1. bing.com/webmasters — you can import directly from your verified GSC property, saves time
2. Submit the same sitemap

robots.txt

Create/verify at `https://excode.in/robots.txt`:

```
User-agent: *
Allow: /
Disallow: /api/
Disallow: /admin/
Sitemap: https://excode.in/sitemap.xml
```

Phase 2: Analytics

Google Analytics 4 (GA4)

1. Create a GA4 property at analytics.google.com
2. Get the Measurement ID (`G-XXXXXXX`)
3. Install via `gtag.js` snippet in your root layout/head, OR use **Google Tag Manager** (recommended — lets you add more tags later like conversion pixels, without redeploying)
4. Set up key events (GA4 calls conversions "key events"):
 - Sign-up completed
 - Assessment/test started
 - Assessment completed
 - Pricing page view → checkout click
5. Link GA4 to Search Console (Admin → Product Links) — this pulls organic search queries directly into GA4 reports

Google Tag Manager (recommended)

- One container, drop it once in your codebase, manage GA4, ad pixels, LinkedIn Insight tag, etc. from the GTM dashboard without more deploys

Optional but useful

- **Microsoft Clarity** (free) — session recordings + heatmaps, very useful for a product like Excode where UX friction in the assessment flow directly affects conversion
 - **PostHog or Mixpanel** if you want product analytics (funnels, retention) beyond marketing analytics — given Excode is a platform with sandboxed assessments, this is worth it later for understanding drop-off in the test-taking flow
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Phase 3: On-Page SEO

For every important page (home, features, pricing, blog if any):

- ☐ Unique `<title>` tag (50–60 chars) with primary keyword near the front
- ☐ Unique meta description (140–160 chars) — this is your ad copy in search results, write it to get clicks

- ☐ One `<h1>` per page, logical `<h2>`/`<h3>` hierarchy after that
- ☐ Descriptive `alt` text on all images
- ☐ Open Graph + Twitter Card meta tags (so shared links on LinkedIn/Twitter/Instagram show a proper preview card — important since you're doing social content pushes)
- ☐ Canonical tags (`<link rel="canonical">`) on every page to avoid duplicate-content issues
- ☐ Internal linking — link from homepage to feature pages, feature pages to pricing, etc.

Structured Data (Schema.org)

Add JSON-LD for:

- `Organization` schema (name, logo, social profiles) — helps Google Knowledge Panel eligibility
- `SoftwareApplication` or `Product` schema for Excode itself
- `FAQPage` schema if you have an FAQ section — these often get rich results directly in search
- `BreadcrumbList` if you have nested pages

Keyword targeting for Excode specifically

Given Excode is an AI-powered dev-skills assessment platform, target clusters like:

- "developer skill assessment platform"
- "AI coding interview tool"
- "hire developers based on real skills" / "verified coding skills"
- "online coding test platform for hiring"
- "Docker sandbox coding assessment"
- Comparison-intent: "[Competitor] alternative" pages (e.g. HackerRank/Codility alternative) — these convert well because the searcher already has buying intent

Phase 4: Technical SEO & Performance

Google's ranking algorithm directly factors in **Core Web Vitals**:

- ☐ Run PageSpeed Insights on `excode.in` — fix anything flagged red
- ☐ LCP (Largest Contentful Paint) < 2.5s — usually means optimizing hero image/font loading
- ☐ CLS (Cumulative Layout Shift) < 0.1 — reserve space for images/ads so layout doesn't jump
- ☐ INP (Interaction to Next Paint) < 200ms
- ☐ Since you're on AWS: consider putting **CloudFront** in front of your app for CDN caching + faster global TTFB, and compress assets (gzip/brotli) at the ALB/Nginx level

- ☐ Mobile responsiveness check — Google indexes mobile-first
 - ☐ Compress/lazy-load images (WebP format where possible)
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Phase 5: Keyword Rank Tracking

You'll want a rank tracker since GSC only shows ~16 months of historical data and doesn't do competitor tracking:

Tool	Notes
Google Search Console	Free, shows actual impressions/clicks/position — your primary source of truth
Ahrefs Webmaster Tools	Free tier for verified site owners, decent keyword + backlink data
Ubersuggest	Cheap, good for early-stage keyword research
SERPWatcher / Semrush	Paid, better for tracking specific keyword positions daily if budget allows later

Start with GSC + Ahrefs Webmaster Tools (both free) — no need to pay for Semrush/Ahrefs full until you have real budget.

Phase 6: Off-Page SEO (Backlinks)

- ☐ Submit Excode to relevant directories: Product Hunt, BetaList, SaaSHub, AlternativeTo, G2 (as a new listing), Capterra
 - ☐ Write a launch post on **Dev.to**, **Hashnode**, or **Medium** linking back to excode.in — dev-focused audiences overlap perfectly with your product
 - ☐ Get listed on "best coding assessment tools" roundup articles if possible — outreach to those blog authors
 - ☐ LinkedIn/Instagram content (which you're already planning) — social signals don't directly rank you, but they drive referral traffic and backlinks organically when people share
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Phase 7: Ongoing Monitoring Cadence

- **Weekly:** Check GSC for new crawl errors, check GA4 for traffic anomalies
 - **Bi-weekly:** Check keyword position movement in Ahrefs Webmaster Tools
 - **Monthly:** Review Core Web Vitals report, review top-performing/worst-performing pages, plan next content/backlink push
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Quick priority order if you want to do this in one sitting

1. Fix HTTPS/canonical/redirect setup (Phase 0)
2. GSC + sitemap submission (Phase 1)
3. GA4 + GTM install (Phase 2)
4. Title tags, meta descriptions, OG tags on your top 5 pages (Phase 3)
5. Run PageSpeed Insights, fix critical issues (Phase 4)
6. Everything else can roll out over the following 2–3 weeks